questions reportedly matched those in the actual exam. The National Testing Agency (NTA), the body responsible for conducting NEET, cancelled it on May 12—the first full cancellation of the exam in its history—and held a retest on June 21. Independent tallies place the number of aspirants who ended their lives in the 46 days between the cancellation and the retest from 11 to 13. Protesters claim the figure exceeded 21. There is no official count, or any compensation so far.



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

VOX POP

"AN UNFAIR SYSTEM"

KAJAL | 22
SSC aspirant, Uttar Pradesh

If exams were genuinely fair, why would re-examinations keep becoming necessary, again and again? Delayed results and punishingly high cut-offs have only deepened the despair among young aspirants. Real reform is impossible unless accountability is fixed first.

NEET is no outlier. One decade-long database counts 89 suspected leaks and 48 retests affecting at least 65 million candidates. Another documents 41 leaks across 15 states in five years. Congress leader Rahul Gandhi cites 152 leaks over a decade, disrupting the lives of 75 million students. Accountability has been rarer than wrongdoing: of 45 major leak cases over two decades, each involving at least 100,000 candidates, only two resulted in convictions.

The government maintains it has not ignored the crisis. The Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024, is the first central law aimed at organised cheating. It covers examinations conducted by the UPSC (Union Public Service Commission), State Service Commission, NTA, Railway Recruitment Boards and banking recruitment bodies, and makes all offences cognisable and non-bailable. Individuals face imprisonment of 3-5 years and fines up to Rs 10 lakh. As for the NEET lapse, the government says it swiftly arrested those involved, handed the investigation to the Central Bureau of Investigation, conducted the retest and published the results, without allowing the admission calendar to collapse.

The failure, however, is institutional as much as legal. The NTA, created in 2017 to standardise entrance exams, is not a statutory body like the UPSC. It is a society registered under an 1860 Act—a legally lightweight institution without a permanent cadre. It depends on deputed officials, and outsources printing, warehousing and transportation to private vendors. Its pen-and-paper model multiplies those risks. The K. Radhakrishnan committee's 101 recommendations, submitted in October 2024, proposed encrypted question papers printed at secure centres, psychometric normalisation and at least 1,000 permanent testing centres. Digital gaps and bureaucratic inertia delayed their adoption. Only after this year's fiasco did the NTA decide to shift NEET to computer-based



PTI

VOX POP

"DEMOCRACY DEMANDS DIALOGUE"

ANGEL GUPTA | 18
Class 12 graduate, Faridabad, Haryana



REUTERS